

Belize



Belize lies on the eastern shore of the Yucatan Peninsula. Formerly called British Honduras, Belize was the last Central American country to gain its independence, in 1981.



GEOGRAPHY

Almost half the land area is forested. Low mountains in southeast. Flat swampy coastal plains.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Very hot and humid, with May–December rainy season.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

English-speaking black Creoles are outnumbered by Spanish speakers, including native *mestizos* and immigrants from neighboring states. The Creoles have traditionally dominated society, but high levels of emigration to the US have weakened their influence. The Afro-Carib *garifuna* have their own language. Corruption, and trafficking of people and narcotics, are major problems.



INSIGHT: Belize's barrier reef is the second-largest in the world



THE ECONOMY

Tourism, agriculture, and offshore banking. Oil extraction began in 2005. Sugar, textiles, lobsters, and shrimp are exported. Serious hurricane damage is a recurring problem.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Belize

DATE OF FORMATION: 1981

CAPITAL: Belmopan

POPULATION: 306,800

TOTAL AREA: 8867 sq. miles
(22,966 sq. km)

DENSITY: 35 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English Creole, Spanish, English*, Mayan, Garifuna (Carib)

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 62%, other 20%, Anglican 12%, Methodist 6%

ETHNIC MIX: Mestizo 49%, Creole 25%, Maya 11%, other 9%, Garifuna 6%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Belizean dollar = 100 cents